

Bet You Didn't Know

Multiple Clips In Adobe Premiere

In Adobe Premiere, you can drag multiple clips to the Source window, and choose between them in the pop-up. To clear the clips stored in the Source window, use [Ctrl] + Backspace. This will delete the currently visible clip and move the others up the list—subsequent deletes will remove the later clips.

you increments of one per cent and display a delta or offset value next to the adjustment.

Backwards

To play a clip backwards, right-click on a clip and set the 'Speed' option to -100 per cent. Alternately, you can also select a clip and choose 'Speed' from the Clip menu.

Palette Dock

Most people don't know that if you drag a palette to just below another one, they 'dock' vertically. This is great for managing screen real estate since moving one palette moves the others with it. Press [Tab] to hide the palettes, and [Ctrl] + [Tab] to toggle between the timeline and monitor panes.

Flash MX 2004

Navigation

Navigating through scenes and symbols can be achieved by pressing [Shift] + [F2] and [Ctrl] + [L], for scenes and the Library respectively.

Restoring

Well, you messed it up all, the stage looks pathetic and you want to just get rid of everything. What do you do?

The easiest way to erase everything on the Stage is to double-click the Eraser tool in the toolbar. However remember that this works only on one frame at a time, i.e. if the playhead is at frame

13, it will erase everything on Stage at frame 13. To erase other frames move the playhead to those frames.

Edit Bar

With the release of Flash MX 2004, Macromedia did some tweaking with the interface; while some were good, others were irritating. One of them was moving the Edit bar from underneath the timeline. Want to know how to get it back?

Pressing [Ctrl] + [Shift] and double-clicking on the Edit bar will move it to its rightful original position under the Timeline.

To remove the Edit bar from your workspace again, choose **Window > Toolbars > Edit Bar**. It's gone forever!

The Edit bar serves three basic functions Zooming in and out of the Stage, navigating through looped or nested Timelines, and navigating through scenes and symbols. These functions can be performed by some tricks without touching the Edit bar.

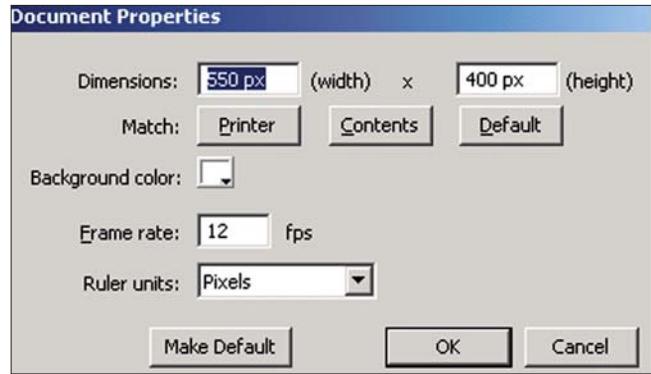
Zooming

To zoom, press [Ctrl] then press any number on your number pad between [1] and [8]. These numbers represents zoom levels. So when [Ctrl] + [1] is pressed it represents 100 per cent zoom, [Ctrl] + [3] zooms to 300 per cent and so on. If using shortcuts isn't your thing, you can use the Zoom tool. Click to zoom in and [Alt] + Click to zoom out.

The Stage

By default the stage is fixed to 550 x 400 because this is the largest size a flash movie can be, to fill the browser window at 800 x 600. But hardly anybody uses such a big stage; moreover many Flash projects require custom settings.

To modify the stage settings, open the Document Properties dialog box and change the Stage dimensions to something that you generally use for most of your projects. You can also change the



Defining the dimensions of the stage in Flash MX 2004

background colour and frame rate as well. To make these changes permanent, click Make Default, so every time you launch a new document, the Stage will use these settings.

Printing Dummies

Let's say you've created 15 dummy frames, and then realise that you have to take printouts of them. 15 odd frames of content will take forever to print, and also waste a lot of paper and ink. There's a better way:

In the File menu, select 'Print Margins'. In the subsequent dialog box, leave the margin settings as they are and choose All Frames from the Frames menu, and then Storyboard boxes from the Layout menu. Click OK and then Print ([Ctrl] + [P]).

This will print all the frames, in boxes on a single sheet of paper. The trick for effective presentation is to have some difference in subsequent frames.

Flip-books

Since you already have the animation ready, it can be used to make a flip book. To print the animation, convert it to a movie clip and print the symbol's Timeline. Once printed, cut apart the squares on the printed page and staple them together in chronological order of your movie. Now just flip through the pages to see the animation and you've got yourself a flip-book!

Images

Bitmaps are often used in Flash movies and

that add makes the movie bulky—not good for Flash. One can reduce the size of the JPEG images by tweaking the Publish settings for the entire length of the movie, but more often than not, this plays havoc with the pictures—one may look OK but the next might have noise.

To customize the publish settings for individual bitmap images, right-click on the image's name in the Library and choose 'Properties'.

In the 'Bitmap Properties' dialog box, deselect 'Use document default quality' and then change the number in the 'Quality' field. Higher numbers result in higher-quality images with a larger file size. Lower numbers result in lower quality and lower file size. After you set the number, click 'Test'.

The dialog box reports the starting file size and the new file size for the image. Typically, setting the Quality to 50 can make a 500 KB image publish at less than 20 KB!

You can also use the mouse to drag the image around in the preview pane of the dialog box to see how it will look. If it's grainy, raise the number in the Quality field. If it still looks perfect, you can decrease the quality even more.

Organisation

Perfection is all about organising. When working with Flash you have to deal with two files, the raw working original files and the published files. Separating them into two separate folders tends to increase over all readability.